Certificates Focus Groups Results, August 2024

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Research Objectives:

1. Identify resources, motivations, & outcomes: Existing resources, extrinsic and intrinsic motivations for acquiring a certificate and how they line up against actual outcomes.
2. Identify common pain points & understand ideal experience: Pain points with certificate programs and understanding what would improve or enhance their experience with certificates. What are the opportunities that we should be ideating around to get product / market fit to solve potential pain points?
3. Map out the certifications decision-making process: Understand the purchase journey
4. Gather concept reactions and evaluate masterClass PMF: what are initial reactions for MC branded concept here and does MasterClass have permission to play within certificates space (according to consumers)?

Participants: N=11 Non-members (5-6 per group), 2 focus groups total

Research plan | Discussion guide | Concept shown

Findings

1. **Motivations to pursue certificate programs** (full list here)
    a. **Primary motivation** is to become a **more valuable asset in the job market**.
    "I become a more valuable asset with the more things that I can prove that I can do"
    "Giving yourself more expertise or a wider range of skills – it's going to make you more sought after and paid better."

    b. **Motivations are primarily extrinsic** and include **career advancement**, **financial gain**, **job security**, and **staying relevant**.
    "Money. There is more money with more certifications."

    c. **Intrinsic motivations** (few) are to pursue **passion for learning** (i.e., lifelong learners) and/or for **personal fulfillment** (i.e., continuous self-improvement)

2. **Challenges faced when pursuing certificate programs** are primarily lack of support, low quality feedback, time, staying engaged, and unclear prerequisites + outcomes. (full list of challenges here)
    a. **Lack of support, both during and after the course:** no one to ask questions to when stuck, and insufficient guidance with resume help, job search, and exploring additional certifications

    b. **Low quality feedback**: programs rely too heavily on peer feedback, which is often of lower quality, leading to a preference for more expert input.
    "My Coursera program had a lot of peer-graded assignments…the feedback I was getting was not great. I wish an instructor or someone from Google review[ed] my work. [It seemed] even if I would've submitted a blank paper, [peers wouldn't notice]"

💡 **How can we…support as questions arise and provide meaningful feedback on assignments and projects during the course?**

💡 **How can we…guide and support students AFTER ?**

- ➢ Can we assist with posting their certifications, including guidance on language, platforms, and methods? / Can we help them share their achievements with a broader network?
- ➢ Can we support them in demonstrating their increased value to their current employer or connect them with job opportunities that match their new skills?
- ➢ Can we help them understand how their skills are transferable?

c. **Too lengthy:** Challenges in managing time, with assignments or the program overall taking longer than expected.
"*I feel like as time went on, I kind of lost motivation and momentum that"*

d. **Staying motivated and engaged:** participants mentioned losing interest due to long course durations and lack of engaging content (interactive elements, boring instructors). Breaking up content into **15-20 minute, manageable chunks** and ensuring **varied learning formats** could help maintain engagement.

e. **Unclear communication of prerequisites + outcomes**: Many expressed frustration with vague course descriptions and the lack of transparency about what to expect, which led to unmet expectations. Providing **clearer communication of prerequisites and course objectives**, **without overpromising** is key.

3. **<u>Journey map</u> of the certification decision-making process**: (see full map here)

a. **Initial awareness**: Journey typically starts with identifying a need for new skills or credentials, often driven by job requirements, industry demands, or in some cases, personal goals. Awareness of programs typically arises through online searches (Google), word of mouth (colleagues), job boards, or LinkedIn profiles.

b. **Evaluation and Comparison**: Options are then evaluated based on brand / institute reputability (most important), cost, course objectives (alignment with goals), and delivery format + length. Instructors credentials, engagement, and teaching experience are also factored in.

i. At this stage, reviews, testimonials, trial access, and colleague recommendations are crucial in helping to narrow down options.

ii. **Trial access is preferred for evaluating the instructor's engagement** as well as the overall appeal of the content.
"Just listening through a few of them to see which one's going to stick with you, which one's going to feel like it's going to give you the better benefit"

iii. **Transferability of Skills:** Participants seek out certificates that provide skills applicable in various job contexts, not just narrowly defined roles. Participants value certifications that enhance their versatility and open up broader career opportunities. – *"It's important that the certification helps me in many different endeavors instead of just specific job training... it should be transferable"*

c. **Purchase / decision**: The final decision is influenced by perceived value, alignment with career goals, and the credibility of the institution. Participants seek tangible benefits, such as enhanced job prospects or skill improvement, with the core question being: "Will this certification make me a more valuable asset in the job market?"

d. **Assessment of credibility at the final stage**:

i. **Assessment of credibility is highly tied to its industry acceptanc**e. If a certification is commonly acknowledged by industry leaders, it enhances the participant's employability – "*I want it to be from a place that's recognized in my industry so that employers know it's worth something"*

ii. **The credibility of the issuing institution acts as a guarantee of the program's quality.** Participants view certifications from these sources as more likely to be beneficial for career advancement because they trust these institutions to uphold rigorous standards. – *"Having a certification from a well-known and respected university or company means that the quality of the education is likely higher and more trusted by employers"*

iii. **The number of reviews and testimonials serves as evidence of success**: A proven track record reassures participants that their investment in time and money will pay off, as the certification has demonstrable value in the job market. – *"are there thousands of reviews? are there just a few or just 100 or so? This helps me gauge how effective the certification might be"*

4. **<u>Concept reactions and evaluating MasterClass product-market fit</u>**:

a. **Concept reactions**:

i. **Overall structure:** Participants were shown the MasterClass certificate program concept, and were positively surprised by the depth and interactive elements (like quizzes and projects) of the MasterClass certificate program concept.

ii. **Topic of AI:** The choice of Artificial Intelligence as a topic was seen as highly relevant and appealing and caught the attention of participants.

iii. **Leveling & length**: Skepticism arose around whether a short 15-hour course could effectively teach machine learning skills as advertised.

iv. **Willingness to buy:** Willingness to pay hinges on expert instructors and whether the certificate would be recognized or respected in their industry, indicating they would need to research alternative options.

b. **MasterClass PMF**: Participants view MasterClass as more of a platform for inspirational learning rather than formal education or professional certifications. They associated it with celebrity-led, non-technical courses, which made them skeptical about its fit in the certification space. Participants expressed concerns about whether MasterClass's current format would engage them in a meaningful way, especially for certifications that require deeper, technical learning.

c. **MC Partnerships for credibility**: Indeed, leveraging p**artnerships with reputable universities or industry leading companies** will enhance the credibility of our certification programs, making them more attractive to potential learner. Echoing feedback from past quantitative research conducted among non-members highlighting the importance of collaborating with top universities. Report: Certifications Research, Non-Members (June 2024)

Questions for further explorations:

- What types of feedback would users be willing to pay more for?
- What types of feedback would they expect in the current structure?

Table A. Certificate Motivations

Motivation Type	Motivation	Remarks
Intrinsic	Desire for **continuous self-improvement** and staying updated.	*"I think one of my motivations is just that each industry changes rapidly and you just want to constantly better oneself and know what's trending."*
	Learning for **personal satisfaction** and enjoyment. **Pursuit of knowledge** for its own sake	*"I'm a lifelong learner. It's something I do for enjoyment and entertainment."* *"It was more personal wanting to get the knowledge, but at the same time having a credential."*
	Freedom to **pursue personal interests** and passions.	*"You can actually learn what you want to learn rather than when you're in high school or in college, you're forced to learn specific subjects that you may not be personally passionate about."*
Extrinsic	**Financial gain** ($$)	*"Money. There is more money with more certifications."*
	Continuous learning for **career progression**. Using certifications as a stepping stone for a **career change**.	*"You're not going to stay stagnant if you're, you know, you can be happy with your position. And if that's where you are, you just meet the minimum requirements. That's fine. But that's not me. I want to continuously progress and you have to continuously learn if you're going to do that."* *"It is more of a career change. I've been in [finance] for the past 15 years and I'm kind of burned out on it so I'm branching out into that area of work (I like)."*
	Gaining diverse skills to **enhance employability and value**.	*"More like a Swiss Army knife that you feel that you're bringing more value to the table."* *"I become a more valuable asset with the more things that I can prove that I can do."* *"Giving yourself more expertise or a wider range of skills, it's going to make you more sought after and paid better."*
	Staying relevant / up-to-date	*"Just keeping up with all the latest and greatest technology and understanding what we're providing to our customers."*

Table B. Pain Points

Pain Points When Selecting a Program (ordered from most to least significant)

Pain Point	Description	Related Quotes
Cost	Concerns about the affordability and value for money when selecting a certification program.	*"If it was at an affordable price... I didn't want to put a lot of money into it unless it was something that I knew was going to be worth it."* *"I figured going into it, it wasn't going to be a lot of money for the value that I was gaining from it."*
Narrowing Down	Difficulty in choosing the right program from multiple options.	*"Trying to figure out which program was going to give me what I was looking for."* *"There were so many options... narrowing it down was a bit of a challenge."*
Clearly Defined Prerequisites	Frustration with programs not listing minimum requirements or assuming prior knowledge.	*"Some courses I've taken recently... they're labeled intro... but some of the content in there is without explanation of how they got there."* *"It wasn't listed that it's assumed that you know this much at least, because this is where we're starting off. Had I read that, I wouldn't have taken it."*
Understanding Goals/ Application	The need to understand how the program aligns with personal or career goals.	*"Understanding which program gives me what I'm looking for and will it give me what it promises?"* *"I found it hard to visualize what it was going to be like doing the training and certification until I actually signed up for it."*
Clearly Defined Objectives	The importance of having clear, specific objectives for the course content.	*"Clearly defined objectives... not just objectives, but specific milestones and things that can be mapped to job descriptions."* *"The course description said 'Become a SQL ninja.' Okay, but what does that actually mean?"*
Sales/ Marketing Fluff (Overpromising)	Skepticism about whether the program can deliver on its promises, especially when marketing language is used.	*"They're really creating this marketing narrative to make you feel like, 'Well, this will be the certification that changes your life.'* *"I feel like the certification was sold to me as something way better than it actually was."*

Pain Points While Pursuing a Program (ordered from most to least significant)

Pain Point	Description	Related Quotes
Lack of Support	Issues with not having access to help when questions arise regarding the material	*"would have would almost be like office hours with the instructor or a equivalent of like a TA"* *"[In an ideal experience] there would be 24/7 support."*

	or issues with completing tasks or assignments.	*“Ability to just ask – I'm stuck on XYZ lesson – that ability alone is pretty big.”* *“if [I could] get answers to questions [from experts], I might actually pay for [a MC cert] because then I'm going to learn stuff more quickly”*
Low Quality Feedback	Lack of meaningful feedback from instructors or peers.	*"No professional that was very experienced... that I could ask for help."* *"I wish there would’ve been an instructor or someone from Google reviewing my work versus [a peer] in the course."* *“My Coursera program had a lot of peer-graded assignments. I felt like the feedback I was getting was not great.”*
Too lengthy	Challenges in managing time, with assignments or the program overall taking longer than expected.	*"Sometimes the assignments... estimated three to four hours"* *“The biggest [pain point] was time. It was advertised as 6 months, 10 hours a week. They underestimated how long it was going to take. As time went on, I kind of lost motivation and momentum”* *“I need the lessons broken up into like 20 minute chunks. I don't really care if it's like 5, 20, or 15 min chunks, because I get interrupted…with “real work”*
Organization/ Structure	Problems with poor structure and jumping between topics.	*"instructor would bounce around...and you get confused."* *"[course] organization was all over the place [made] it hard to follow along."* *"Content wasn't organized well...made it difficult to understand the flow"*
Staying Motivated/ Lost Interest	Difficulty in staying motivated	*"if the format was a little too homogenous, I just lost interest.* *"Honestly, mine was just like if it was too boring, I just lost interest."* *“[for some instructors] I will fall asleep if I, if I have to listen to this person, sounds like nails on a chalkboard- can't do it.”*
Understanding of Next Steps	The need for clarity on what the next steps are after completing a course or how it fits into a larger learning or career path.	*- "Knowing what the next steps after a certain class are can be frustrating."* *- "I want to see a clear path—if I take SQL 1, what's the next step? Can I branch off into finance or healthcare?"* *– “[an ideal program] looking at what next steps will be for this particular certification, so that you understand whatever step you take next, how that will or will not help you in what you're looking to do professionally. And I think the goal out of all of this is to create a sense of empowerment, so that when you make your step, you're making it from an informed place, and that it can support ongoing development, so you understand the benefits of whatever you decide to do.*

Table C. Certificate Programs Consumer Journey Map

	👀 Awareness →	💡Consideration →	🛍️ Purchase
Triggers / Factors	**Triggers**: ● Job requirements ● Industry demands ● Personal goals These lead them to recognize the need for new skills or credentials.	**Factors considered to narrow down options:** ● Reputability / credibility of brand / institute (#1) ● Course objectives and topics covered ● Delivery format & length ● Instructor: credentials, engagement, teaching experience ● Price	**Triggers:** The final decision often hinges on **perceived value for the money** which is understood by assessing: ● relevance to career goals ● credibility of the issuing institution ● provides **transferable skills**
Pain point	● Overwhelming number of options ● Hard to know which is reputable	● Unclear course objectives and outcomes ● Uncertainty about course value and effectiveness	● Unable to trial before committing
Sources	Online searches, WOM (typically colleague recommendations), or job boards (Indeed, LinkedIn, Dice)	Reviews, testimonials, and recommendations from colleagues play a crucial role in this stage. **Trials are a crucial step** used t**o <u>evaluate instructor engagement</u> and content interest**	● Review if outcomes align with goals ● Trial period engages them enough
Actions taken	● Searching online, ● speaking with colleagues, ● checking job boards to find relevant certification programs. ● Reviewing LI profiles	Comparing different options by reviewing ● Reviews & testimonials ● speaking with peers, ● (if offered) Take a trial	● Finalizing the decision by evaluating the cost-benefit ratio, considering the credibility of the institution, and potential career impact.
Quotes	*"It was really just doing a Google search and hoping to find something reputable."* *"I found out mine through word of mouth… talking to colleagues about ones that they've done"* *"I looked at their LinkedIn and like, I saw that they had these certificates and so I asked them like, Hey, like, what'd you think about this course?"*	*"I searched for SQL and took the (trial) and kind of start playing it in the background for long enough to see if it sounded interesting"* *"I would always look for reviews...then that kind of tells me how many people are using it...Are there thousands of reviews? Are there just a few?"* *"[for some instructoria] It was like I will fall asleep if I, if I have to listen to this person, sounds like nails on a chalkboard- can't do it."*	*"Just listening through a few of them to see which one's going to stick with you, which one's going to, you feel like it's going to give you the better benefit"* *"[A must have is if it was coming from like a reputable brand and then if it was at an affordable price"* *"It is something that is reputable and transferable… isn't from an unknown place, I don't want to start up, I want to tried-and-true"*

Table D. Certificate Competitors Mentioned

Competitors	Quotes
Coursera	*“Coursera has a good reputation... It also makes me feel more comfortable that what I'm learning is accurate and up to date."* *"Harvard University, for example, they tout that they have a bunch of free college courses that they put on Coursera that anyone can access."*
Google / Coursera	*"The Google project management course... to better understand different types of project management skills and hopefully transition from my current job to another one."* *"I recently completed the Google Project Management Certificate through Coursera."*
Udemy	*"We use Udemy quite a bit."* *"I do leverage Udemy and I have with Coursera before just as additional aids with those certifications."*
Linkedin Learning	*"I got sent to LinkedIn Learning by my boss."* *"Work pays for LinkedIn Learning."*
ServiceNow Learning	*"With ServiceNow, essentially, most of those certifications are through the ServiceNow Now Learning."*

Potential Personas:

Persona:
Ambitious professional seeking to advance their career. They are busy, mid-career stage, aiming to deepen technical expertise (e.g., SQL advancements) and/or refine leadership, soft skills to advance within their field, while balancing work, family, and personal goals.

- *"So I look towards online learning to upskill myself. Recently took a class in SQL."*
- *"In a busy life and, you know, while working and family and all those things, there's really no better alternative to meet that than flexibility in e-learning."*
- *"It's about improving myself, and giving myself more expertise or a wider range of skills. It's going to make me more sought after and paid better."*

Problem
Challenges such as unclear course objectives, lack of immediate support in online learning environments, and at times non-credible, boring instructors.

- *"Clearly define objectives. In the description: become a SQL ninja... but what does that mean? Need for milestones that map to job descriptions."*
- *"Some [instructors] voices I don't like, especially if I'm paying for it and there's so many options. Like, why put yourself through something that [isn't engaging], when you have another option?"*

MC Solution
MasterClass provides structured, flexible, and engaging courses taught by credible, engaging instructors who combine practical expertise with strong teaching skills, offering clear, actionable objectives to align learning with career growth goals.

- *"It definitely needs to be taught by educators and not just practitioners—people who understand learning objectives and how to teach coding."*

Alternative
Other e-learning platforms, cohort-based programs, or leveraging industry connections and self-guided resources to acquire necessary skills for advancement.

- *"I have previously participated in an e-learning class that was more cohort-based, so there was project-based learning, meetings, and discussions."*
- *"I was lucky to have a community of people for most of my skills to reach out to."*

Persona
Mid-career professionals dissatisfied with their current field (e.g., banking), seeking a structured path to switch careers and develop practical skills in a new domain (e.g., project management.

- "Yeah, for me, mine was more about a career transition because I've been in banking for eight years and kind of getting sick of it. It's just not like the best environment in general for me to work in, and I wanted to explore something different."

Problem

Challenges in selecting the right certification program, receiving adequate support, and gaining actionable skills for the transition.

- *"I think also it was hard for me to visualize what it was going to be like doing the training and certification until I actually signed up for it."*

MC Solution

MasterClass provides engaging, skill-focused learning with clear articulation of value and support mechanisms (e.g., live chat or accessible resources) to ensure learners feel guided and confident in their investment.

- *"For me, it's the lack of help and stuff. It really bothers me if I get stuck somewhere, and I feel like I got screwed out of the money and the time."*
- *"I want to be able to know that there's a live chat or something."*

Alternative

Other certification programs (e.g., Google or professional organizations), self-guided learning through books or free online resources, or staying in their current career due to frustration with the alternatives.